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Prisoner of a Family Legacy

As with Narendra Modi, 2012 was a crucial year for the Congress's heir apparent Rahul Gandhi as well. He was turning forty-two, still 'young' by Indian political standards but no longer a novice in public life. If the Gujarat assembly election battlefield at the end of that year was Modi's Kurukshetra, then the Uttar Pradesh elections at the start of it were a severe test for the man blessed with the most famous surname in Indian politics.

Uttar Pradesh was, after all, not just the most populous state in the country—it was the *karmabhoomi* of the Gandhi–Nehru family stretching back several generations. The family tag had bestowed him with a 'national' leader status almost instantly, but Rahul Gandhi needed to prove himself on home turf to the Congress party and beyond. Rahul understood that, which is why through much of the summer of 2011 he had slogged it out in the heat and dust of UP, courting arrest during a farmers' agitation over land acquisition in the western UP village of Bhatta Parsaul and then starting off on a *padyatra* through the affected areas. Sleeves rolled up, both literally and metaphorically, he seemed ready for a big fight.

As the build-up to the UP elections continued, Rahul was drawing crowds and eyeballs. His Hindi had visibly improved, his speeches appeared less staccato and there was a definite energy in his campaign. Through this period, I had been attempting to contact him for an interview. But chasing Rahul is never easy—ensconced in a feudal political structure, the heir to the Congress family fortune would hardly ever reply to email and phone queries. A wall of deafening silence existed between him and me. Which is why I was pleasantly surprised one late evening in the middle of February, while UP was in the midst of a seven-phase marathon election, to